

Rakesh Rao

sportstar@thehindu.co.in

For more than a decade, Viswanathan Anand remained the world chess champion. In the space of 12 years, Anand won five times and became one of the greatest players to have played the game. Strangely, only a handful of Indians watched Anand in action as he went about collecting world titles in three different formats. Even shooter Abhinav Bindra and cueist Pankaj Advani scaled great heights in their illustrious careers in the absence of live images of their conquests in India.

As a welcome move, in recent years, more and more live broadcasts of sporting disciplines have become available, and chess is one of the biggest gainers. In fact, the COVID-19 pandemic proved a boon for chess since it caught the attention of those confined indoors with access to the internet. As a result, young Indians like R. Praggnanandhaa, D. Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi, and Nihal Sarin, among a few others, benefitted immensely. The live images, coupled with their consistent performances, have helped grow the chess community. From the 2022 Chess Olympiad to the 2023 World Cup to the FIDE Candidates 2024, some stupendous Indian performances were hailed.

Till the other day, the biggest gainer was World Cup runner-up Praggnanandhaa. Today, notwithstanding the ongoing IPL, Gukesh's sensational triumph in the Candidates tournament becomes the talking point. Many stayed awake all night to keep track of the final round once it became known that Gukesh had the best chance to win, ahead of three of the top-four players in the world. India woke up to the news of Gukesh, 17, becoming the youngest to win the Candidates and earn the right to challenge the reigning world champion Ding Liren in the world title clash scheduled to begin in late November this year.



The media's urge to immediately reach out to the champion was understandable. Unlike the days when Anand was in his prime, news and visuals travel almost in real-time. No wonder, players like Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa, and a few others are lucky to reap the benefits of this ever-improving technology. Gukesh, younger than Praggnanandhaa by a year, has been in the news since he broke his Chennai mate's record of being the youngest Indian Grandmaster. Given his exploits in cash-rich online chess in the past few years and his triumphs over World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen on a few occasions, Praggnanandhaa has become the face of the new generation of Indian chess

champions. For those following the rise of these two youngsters, it is quite evident that Gukesh steadily rose in the classical time format of the game while Praggnanandhaa was busy sharpening his skills in the shorter duration formats suited for online chess.

Gukesh's rise began in March 2022, days after Praggnanandhaa hit the headlines for stunning Carlsen in online chess. Gukesh came in second to Erigaisi in the National Championship in Kanpur. This was the first time Gukesh played after the pandemic and showed a glimpse of the hard work he had done during the long period of lockdown. Interestingly, around 25 months after taking the top two spots in the